Introduction to problem solving

Problem solving is the essence of what we do – and a skill you can apply throughout your work

"PROBLEM" = the distance between your current state ("As-is") and where the you want to be ("To-be")

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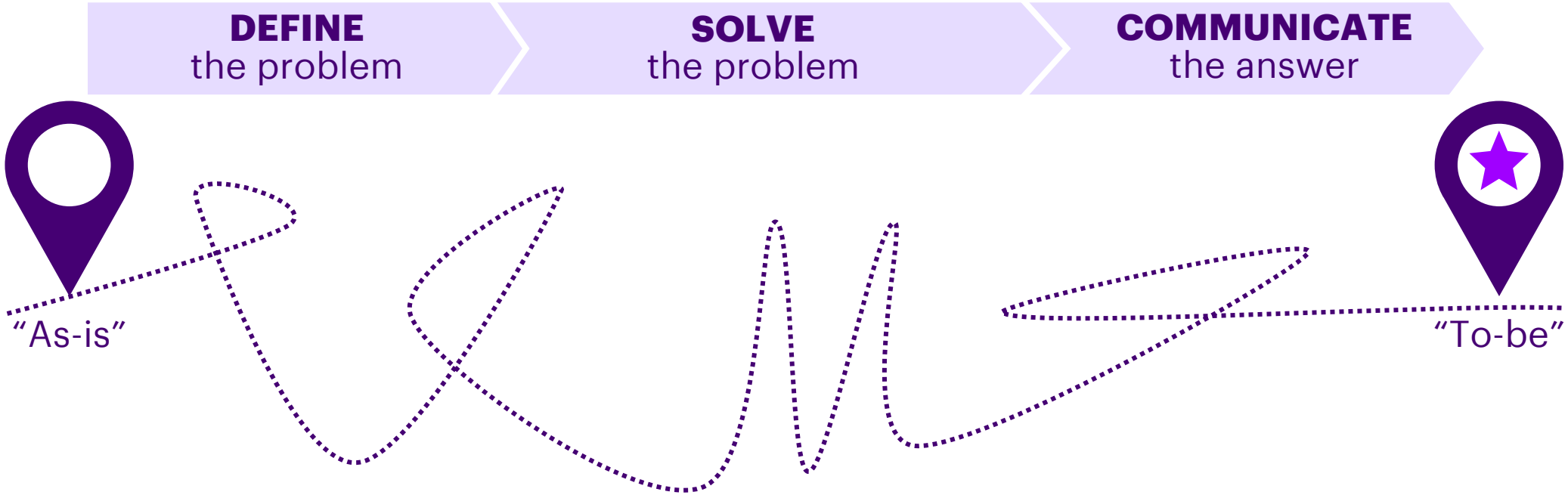
Issue-based problem solving is a structured approach to solving complex issues

STAGES OF ISSUE-BASED PROBLEM SOLVING



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Framing the Problem: S-C-Q

Situation, Complication, Question

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Define the problem by using the S-C-Q framework

SITUATION

Situation (Example):

DataFlow AI sells predictive analytics software to companies in financial services, helping them automate decisions like credit risk scoring and fraud detection.

The situation is the set of simply stated facts that no one can dispute

COMPLICATION

Complication (Example):

New EU regulations now require all AI-driven financial decisions to be fully explainable. DataFlow's models cannot meet this standard, putting its largest client contracts at risk.

The complication is the source of difficulty for the client

QUESTION

Question (Example):

How can DataFlow AI make its models regulation-ready without losing predictive accuracy?

The key question is the most critical for project success

THE 'PROBLEM' IS NOT ALWAYS THE PROBLEM

- ✓ Do not take the client's diagnosis of their problem at face value
- ✓ Dig deeper, ask questions and get the facts
- ✓ You will be doing your client a service by getting to the real problem
- ✓ Focus your attention to the most important issue (' the burning platform')
- ✓ Address the need to change – focus on possible answers to your question, not open-ended

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Examples and discussion

BE SURE YOUR KEY QUESTION IS

- **Simple,** not a compound
- Phrased **clearly** and **accurately**
- **Focused** on the most **important** issue
- Addressing the need to **change**

EXAMPLES

Should we pursue the 1st time buyer market in PCs?

How can BigCo increase sales?

Why were the new product sales poor?

How do we improve the result of the Metropolitan Opera?

Will answering the question make a difference?

2 min

Discussion

How can we improve the question?

How, if at all, should Client X enter the online automotive business, as many of its competitors have, to improve its profitability?

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How~~, if at all, should Client X enter the online automotive business, as many of its competitors have, to improve its~~ can we improve Client X's profitability?

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There are a number of common pitfalls you can encounter when formulating a key question

1. Key question not relevant to client's situation
2. Does not address the complication
3. Too vague, narrow or broad
4. Assumption-driven
5. Several questions in one
6. Agreed to by the client, but not run past all key stakeholders

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Decomposing the Key Question: The Issue Tree

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An issue tree is a powerful tool to structure problem solving

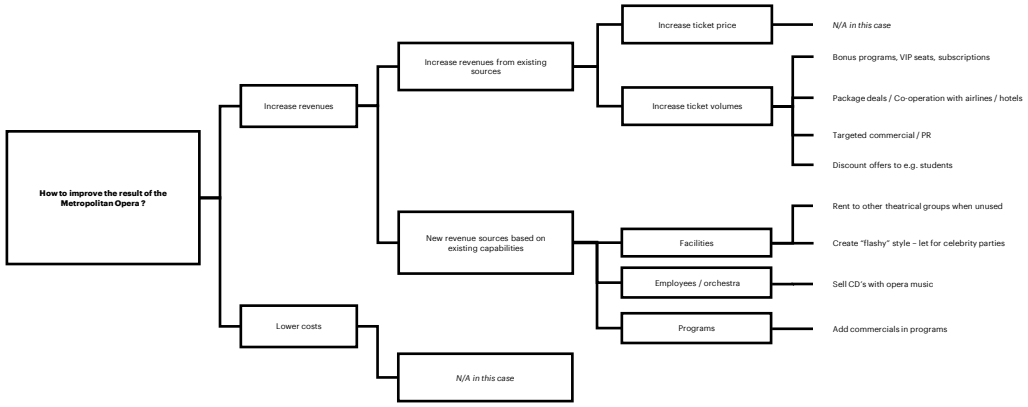
WHY AN ISSUE TREE?

- Identifies sub-problems describing the original problem
- Works on any type of (client) problems
- Gives common understanding of the problem & scope
- Acts as a base for research plan

Smaller and more easier problems to focus and gather data on

HOW TO CREATE AN ISSUE TREE

1. Start with the key question to the left
2. Break down into sub-issues
3. Continue to break down the sub-problems in minor issues
4. Make sure it is **MECE** (Mutually Exclusive Collectively Exhaustive)



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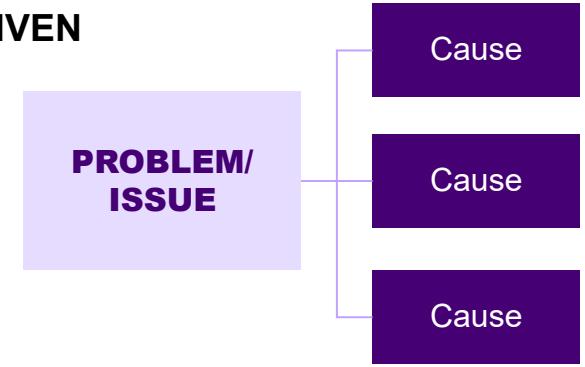
Issue trees are either problem or solution driven

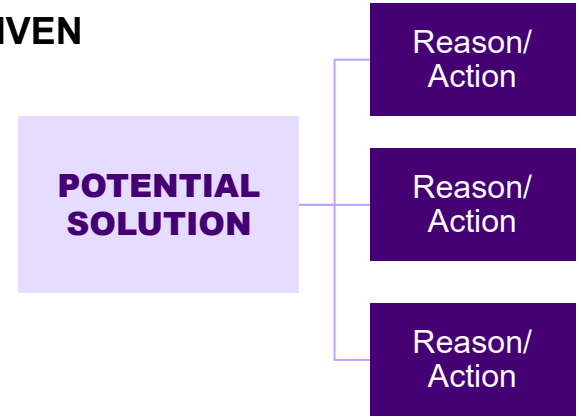
PROBLEM-DRIVEN

Starts with the problem and decomposes it to arrive at a solution

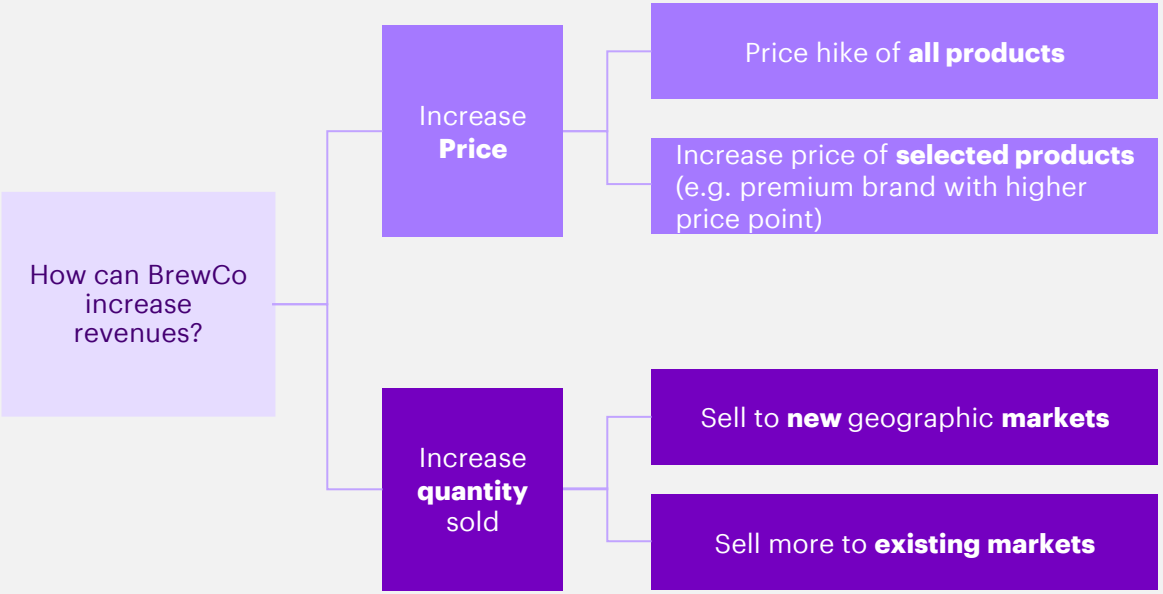


SOLUTION-DRIVEN

Starts with a potential solution and develops a rationale to validate or disprove it



EXAMPLE ON HOW TO BUILD AN ISSUE TREE



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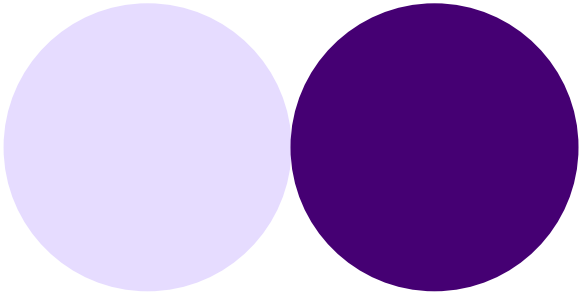
What is Mutually Exclusive, collectively Exhaustive (MECE)?

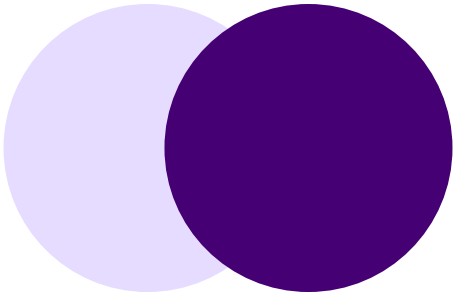
Mutually exclusive



Population distribution

- 0-20
- 21-40
- 41-60
- 61-80
- 81+

NOT mutually exclusive



Population distribution

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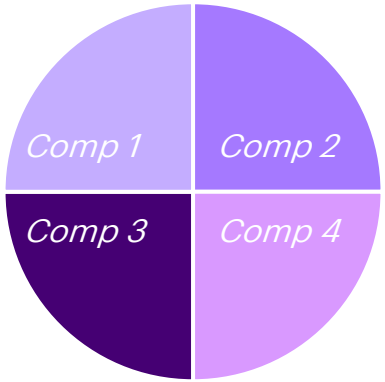
- 80+

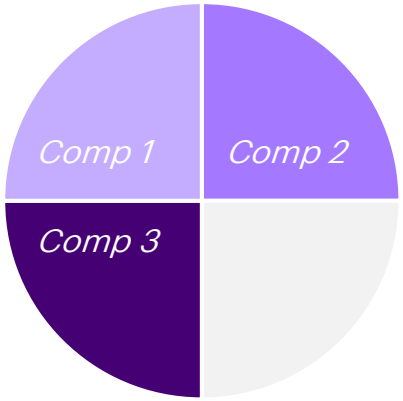
Collectively exhaustive



Numbers on a dice

- 1
- 2
- 3
- 4
- 5
- 6

NOT collectively exhaustive



Numbers on a dice

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Why are issue trees important?

1. Enables identification of **causes** and not just symptoms
(pushing analysis one level deeper at a time)

2. It is easy to **communicate priorities** and next steps to your client with a **visual breakdown**

3. Can be used when **assigning tasks to your team** to avoid double work

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Presenting the answer to the Key Question: The Pyramid Principle

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The three parts of structured communication; introduction, conclusions, and main body

We will go into more details on storytelling in module 3

SET THE SCENE

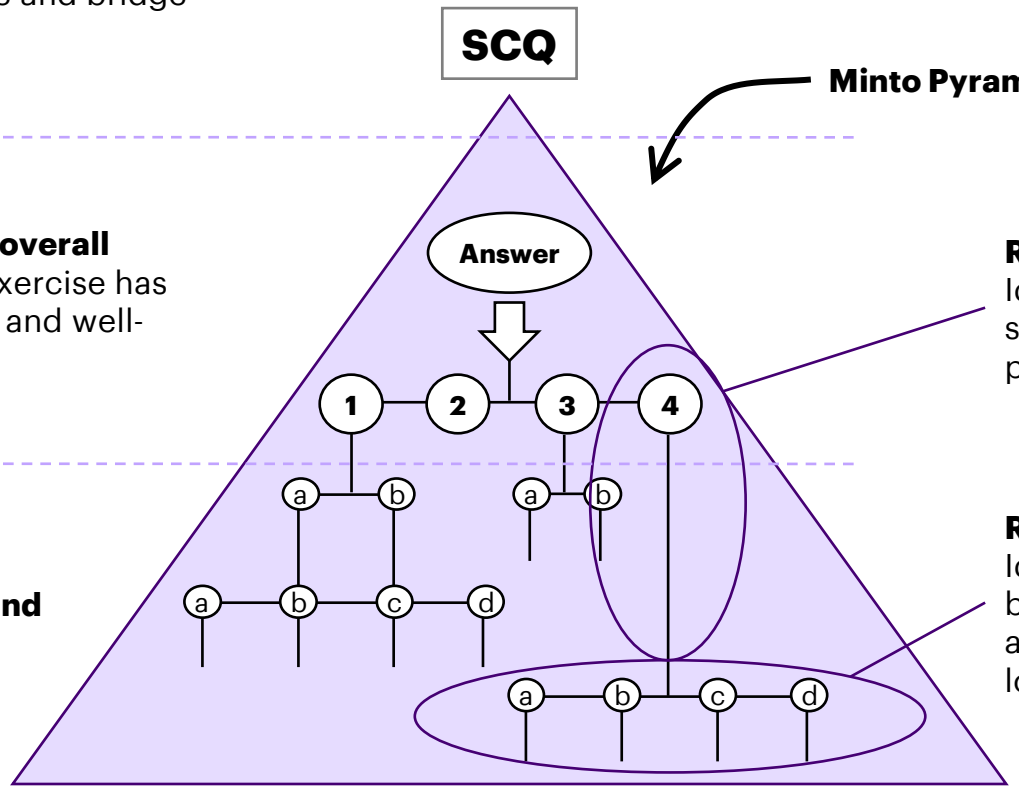
The **SCQ framework is a good approach** to set the scene and bridge to the conclusion.

CONCLUSION

The **main message is the overall conclusion** that regular exercise has positive effects on health and well-being.

MAIN BODY

The main body should provide **specific details and examples** to support the conclusion.



Rule 1: Vertical grouping
Ideas at any level must summarize the ideas presented below them

Rule 2: Horizontal grouping
Ideas in each grouping must be part of the same argument and presented logically

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